

Weekly Writing - Week 1

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1. Statistical Learning and the Limits of AI

In this week's material, the difference between non-social science and social science approaches to statistical learning made me reflect on what "*learning*" actually means. In physics or computer science, patterns can be discovered from data, like measuring objects' falling time we discussed in class, without needing to write down every rule. But in social science, questions such as whether prisons reduce crime require theory and personal interpretation beyond pattern recognition. This raised the question of whether I should let AI do all the work for me. If I let AI do all the work, I risk turning learning into a black box where outputs appear without understanding why. While AI can speed up coding and computation, my responsibility as a student is to understand the concepts, question the assumptions, and interpret the meaning behind the results. Also, connecting the coding output with actual theory to find the social problem is what I'm really passionate about as a Sociology major student!